



IT IS NOT JUST ENOUGH TO BE BIOLOGICALLY YOUNG BUT RATHER TO BE IDEOLOGICALLY YOUNG ENOUGH TO CAPTURE THE YOUTHFUL IMAGINATION

YADAV LECTURES AT MANAGEMENT INSTITUTIONS (LEFT) WHILE RAHUL CATCHES UP WITH COLLEGE STUDENTS

politician and the Facebook leader, the Indian campaign has got smarter. Omar Abdullah's ascent as chief minister was a Facebook event. Abdullah lists dirt bike-racing and scuba diving as his hobbies on his Facebook profile and puts up pictures of vacations and bike-riding with his sons. Even Lalu Yadav, despite his carefully cultivated rustic image, felt the need for a makeover and has acquired a web persona. Politicians are realising that bland bio-datas listing social service activities and charity events are now passé. In this age of personalised politics, the public wants to see the complete man. Advani always brings up the latest book or a movie during campaign talk. The 38-year-old Rahul Gandhi has a natural advantage and his wedding plans are a fascination with college girls, while fans on Facebook reach out to him in short sms sentences, his preferred language: "*Rahul, eager to c u in d office of d pm,*" writes Pausali Sarkar.

His age is an issue with L.K. Advani. As one of India's oldest aspirant for the top job, he is in overdrive to market himself as a tech-savvy, forward-looking man of the times. He recently launched a website with detailed accounts of both his political and leisure time. The idea is to showcase Advani as a man of varied interests and not just a political placard.



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The target of all this hi-tech wrapping is, of course, the young. Advani explains the need to go hi-tech, "There was a time when an entire election was based on public meetings. Democracy has now become a technocracy." His political advisor Sudheendra Kulkarni claims that Advani's experience will score with the youth over the inexperience of younger leaders like Rahul. Visitors to the site are asked to register and offer suggestions. "It makes citizens part of the campaign," says BJP leader Venkaiah Naidu.

It's not just the medium, even the issues are smarter. Governance, development and internal security have higher credibility than populist promises. Advani is right when he says that

the public rally is no longer the sole medium of communication. Hence, the need to accessorise. Loyalists are given *Advani for PM* bumper stickers to prove their ideology. The Congress may be projecting Manmohan Singh as its prime ministerial candidate but it is hoping that Rahul will bring in the youth vote. Recently, Rajnath Singh pointed out that Rahul was but a 'bachcha' still. To which Rahul shot back saying he may be a 'bachcha' but "fortunately or unfortunately, 70 per cent of this country is a 'bachcha' and he should perhaps look at this 'bachcha' part of India".

Touché. But this is one segment that is certainly going to be treated with kid gloves as politicians smarten up to grab this crucial vote. ■